

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CZECHIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the towns, land, and air of Czechia, and one small North Bohemian town proved that even a community facing literal erasure — its houses, its streets, its 750 years of history all marked to be dug up for coal — can stand its ground and win. In the coal country of North Bohemia, whole towns had been demolished under communism to feed the open-pit lignite mines; the historic old town of Most was razed for the coal beneath it. To stop that, the first democratic government drew protective lines in 1991 — the **mining limits** — beyond which the excavators could not go, a guarantee to the surviving communities that they had a future. But a powerful coal company, and governments tempted by the coal, pushed to breach those limits at the **ČSA mine** and dig out the hundreds of millions of tonnes of coal beneath the town of **Horní Jiřetín** and the hamlet of **Černice** — which would have meant demolishing them and moving their people. The town refused. Led by its mayor, joined by environmentalists and a national movement whose very name declared "we are the limits," the people of Horní Jiřetín fought for some twenty years to hold the line. And in 2015 the government decided to keep the limits at ČSA. The town was saved. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a fight is won. North Bohemia had been a sacrifice zone for generations: entire settlements were levelled to reach the lignite beneath them, and the burning of that low-grade coal filled the air with sulphur until the forests of the nearby mountains died from the acid rain. The protective lines drawn after 1989 were meant to end that — a promise that the remaining towns could invest, rebuild, and plan for a future, safe from the excavators. When a private coal company, backed at times by governments hungry for the coal, moved to overturn that promise and reach the seam beneath one more town, the town did not scatter or take the compensation. Its mayor, a builder by trade who restored old houses, became the face of a two-decade refusal; environmentalists set up camp; and a new movement took as its very name the declaration that the people themselves were the limits. When the government finally chose, it kept the line at that mine, and the town of some two thousand people, seven and a half centuries old, remained standing.

The Czechia story teaches two things about defending home and land here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the endurance, and the nation's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Czech, and it was won by a town that would not be dug up. **A protective line, once drawn — a mining limit, a boundary, a guarantee — can be defended, and a determined community that holds that line, for as long as it takes, can save its very existence from a destructive project.** That power — the protective limit, the community that holds the line, the endurance over decades, and the national movement behind it — is Czechia's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made Horní Jiřetín work as a model, and what a later community can copy, was the way it turned an abstract line on a map into a moral promise a nation could rally to. The mining limits were, in law, merely a government resolution about where excavators could dig; but the town and its allies made them into something larger — a solemn guarantee, given to people who had already been moved and demolished under the old regime, that this time their homes and their future would be secure. To breach that limit was no longer a technical adjustment of policy but the breaking of a promise and the digging-up of a living town, and that reframing is what gave the defence its power. Find the protective line, make it a promise the nation will keep, and hold it: that is the template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The 2015 decision that saved Horní Jiřetín **lifted the limits at another mine** nearby, so more coal was dug even as the town was spared — a mixed decision, a line held in one place and given up in another. The town's salvation leaned partly on the **declining economics of the coal itself**, which was becoming less worth mining, not on the resistance alone. And the threat was **long-lived**: the limits are a government decision that a later government could revisit, so the town's twenty-year vigilance had to be constant, and could be needed again. It is worth being candid about how much that vigilance cost and how incomplete the victory was, because both are instructive. For two decades the town lived under a shadow — unable to be sure whether it had a future, its people pressed by offers and uncertainty, its young tempted to leave — and the eventual reprieve, when it came, was mixed: the government kept the line at the town's mine but lifted it at another, so that more coal was dug and other places bore the cost. And the reprieve rested partly on forces outside the town's control, for the particular coal was growing less profitable to extract, which made the political choice to spare the town easier than it might otherwise have been. A community drawn to this example should take heart from the town's survival while being clear-eyed that the win was partial, hard-won, and never fully final. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a community that holds a protective line — and the mixed decisions, the outside forces, and the long, wearing vigilance that

qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a project and assume "the coal is worth too much and the company too strong and nothing can be done," and never organise, never document, never invoke the protective line or hold it. They generate private dread without a public claim. The gap between a town that saves itself and one that is dug up is rarely will — Horní Jiřetín's people showed it for two decades. It is method: knowing how to invoke the protective limit, document the harm, build the movement, and hold the line for as long as it takes.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Czech system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a mine, a demolition, a harmful development, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the limit, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build the evidence and the guarantee)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (organise the town and the nation)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (the limits, the process, and the courts)
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STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it national)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the town organises; a defended limit or a court filing is a headline and a headline builds the movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, a limit held, a town saved. Horní Jiřetín did exactly this — it documented the harm, invoked the limit, built a national movement, and held the line for twenty years.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Czechia's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The protective limit.** A **line drawn in law or policy** — a mining limit, a boundary, a guarantee — can be invoked and defended, as Horní Jiřetín invoked the mining limits. The power of this lever lies in its clarity: a protective limit is a bright, visible line, and a project that would cross it is doing something specific, nameable, and hard to disguise as ordinary progress. Unlike a diffuse argument about environmental harm, which a developer can meet with promises of mitigation, the breach of a firm limit is a binary matter — either the line holds or it does not — and it carries the added weight of a promise made and now to be broken. A community that can point to a clear protective line, and to the guarantee it represented, holds a defence far stronger than a general objection, because it forces the authorities to justify not merely a harm but the deliberate erasure of a boundary they themselves had drawn.
- **The town that holds the line.** A **community determined to save its own existence** is a powerful and legitimate force, as the town's refusal was. This lever draws its strength from a simple moral fact that even a powerful company struggles to override: the demolition of a living community, against its will, to reach the resource beneath it, is an act few societies will openly endorse. A town that refuses to be moved — that keeps its people, rebuilds its houses, and plans for a future in plain defiance of the excavators — turns the project into something the company and the government must justify not against empty land but against homes, families, and a way of life. The determined, visible refusal of a community to be erased is both a practical obstacle and a moral one, and it was exactly Horní Jiřetín's unbowed insistence on remaining a living town that made its demolition politically unbearable.
- **Endurance over decades.** A community that **holds firm for as long as it takes** can outlast a company and a government, as Horní Jiřetín outlasted them for twenty years.
- **The national movement and the climate frame.** A **national movement**, and the **climate and coal-phase-out argument**, can lift a local fight to a national cause.
- **The courts and EU law.** Czechia's **courts and the EU environmental framework** are a real lever a community can wield.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver clean, total wins. The decision that saved Horní Jiřetín was **mixed** — a limit lifted elsewhere. The win leaned partly on the **coal's own decline**. And the threat was **long-lived**, demanding constant vigilance. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Czechia offers — the protective limit, the town that holds the line, the endurance, and the national movement — as Horní Jiřetín used them to save itself from the excavators.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the protective line — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Czech development or extraction project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government. The **government** sets the big decisions — the mining limits, the energy policy, the strategic approvals — and can be moved by public pressure, the courts, and the vote, as the government was moved to keep the limits at ČSA. This point about the government's role deserves emphasis, because the mining limits were the government's own creation, which makes the fight over them distinctive. The limits were not imposed from outside but drawn by a Czech government as a deliberate act of policy and promise, which means the decisive question is whether a later government will keep or break its predecessor's word. A campaign's task, therefore, is to make keeping the promise the politically easier and more honourable course — by rousing the public, invoking the guarantee, and raising the cost of breaking it — so that the government that must choose finds it cannot afford to be the one that dug up a town, as the government that faced Horní Jiřetín's united nation finally could not.

The regional and municipal authorities. Czechia's **regions and municipalities** hold real planning power and are close to their citizens — an accessible and important level, and often the town's first line of defence, as Horní Jiřetín's own council was.

The companies. Mining companies, developers, and utilities — often powerful, sometimes owned by wealthy and connected figures — propose and drive the projects.

The protective limits, the process, and EU law. The **mining limits, the permitting and environmental process, and the EU framework** are real constraints and levers, open to invocation and challenge.

The community and the movement. The **communities, the environmental organisations, and the national movements** are the force that documents, organises, invokes the limits, and holds the line — the force that saved a town.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a company proposal and a government or authority decision, through **permitting and environmental assessment**, toward construction or extraction — with the **community, the courts, and the public** able to invoke the limits, challenge, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Czech doors are the **protective limit**, the **town's determined refusal**, the **endurance**, and the **national movement and climate frame**. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **whether a protective limit or line can be invoked, whether the community will hold, and whether the nation can be roused**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Limit, and the Harm

Behind a project stand a proponent — a company, a developer, sometimes the government — and the officials who approve it. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly in Czechia — **whether a protective limit, boundary, or guarantee protects the place, whether the process and assessment were lawful, what the project does to the town, the land, the air, and the people, and whether the community will hold the line.** Two questions unlock most Czech fights: **Is there a protective limit to invoke, and will the community hold it?** and **Was the process lawful, and can the nation be roused?** The limit and the community's resolve are, together, the heart of most Czech campaigns. The two are inseparable, because a limit is only as strong as the community willing to defend it. A protective line that no one insists upon can be quietly breached, its guarantee forgotten; a community's resolve without a clear line to defend may exhaust itself against a diffuse project. Joined together — the firm limit giving the resolve a clear object, and the resolve giving the limit a living defender — they become formidable, as they did at Horní Jiřetín, where a solemn line and a town that would not be moved reinforced each other for twenty years until the government kept the promise.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, national and, through EU law, ultimately the European Court of Justice; the **mining limits and the environmental process**; the **EU environmental framework**; the **environmental organisations and the national movements**; the **free press**; and

the **public and the voters**, whose united feeling moved the government to keep the limits. In Czechia, the **protective limit, the community that holds the line, the endurance, and the national movement**, backed by the **courts and the public**, are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project that runs up against a protective limit, a town that will not move, a lawful process it cannot satisfy, and a roused nation rarely proceeds — as the excavators at Horní Jiřetín did not. You do not have to choose one front: the same case — the protective limit, the demolition of a town, the flawed process, the climate cost — can go to the government, to the courts, to the press, and to the voters all at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others and helps the community hold the line. A Czech campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together — the solemn limit before the government, the human demolition before the nation, and the flawed process before the courts — so that a government facing a united town, a roused public, a legal challenge, and a limit it would have to be seen to break finds it far easier to keep the line than to cross it, as it found at Horní Jiřetín.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Czech and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether a **protective limit or line** can be invoked, whether the **community will hold**, whether the **process was flawed**, whether the **nation can be roused**, and whether the **courts and EU law** can be engaged. Where a protective limit exists and the community holds firm, Czechia's levers are strong, as Horní Jiřetín showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the win was mixed — a limit lifted elsewhere — that it leaned partly on the coal's decline, and that the threat was long-lived and the vigilance constant.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Invoking the protective limit	45-70%	years	low	The line held; the project blocked
The community holding the line	45-70%	years	low / high resolve	The town's refusal sustained
Endurance over decades	40-65%	years	low / high resolve	Outlasting the company and the government
National movement & climate frame	40-65%	ongoing	low	A local fight made a national cause
Court / process challenge	30-55%	1-3 years	low-moderate	A decision quashed; delay
Media & public pressure	40-65%	ongoing	low	The nation and the government moved
All steps (limit exists, community holds)	45-70%	years	low-moderate	Stopped; the line held; the town saved
All steps (no limit / community wavers)	25-50%	years	low-moderate	Delay; the record; partial

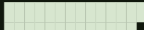
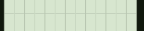
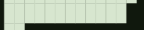
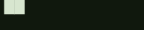
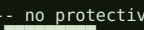
Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Czechia's real strengths are distinctive — the **protective limit**, the **community that holds the line**, the **endurance**, and the **national movement**. Its constraints are specific: the win may be **mixed** — a line held here, given up there; it may lean on **outside forces**; and the threat is **long-lived**, the vigilance constant.

A note on cost: invoking the limit, organising the town, enduring, and building the movement cost mainly time, resolve, and persistence, and Czechia's environmental organisations and national movements supply real support. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the resolve to hold the line for as long as it takes — exactly what Horní Jiřetín gave for twenty years.

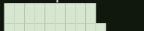
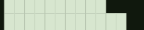
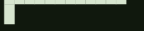
Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (project stopped, limit held, town saved)

A PROTECTIVE LIMIT + A COMMUNITY THAT HOLDS + A ROUSED NATION:

All steps combined:		45-70%
Invoking the limit:		45-70%
Community holds the line:		45-70%
Endurance + movement:		40-65%
Single step:		5-70%

NO LIMIT / COMMUNITY WAVERS -- no protective line, resolve fractures:

All steps combined:		25-50%
Courts + press:		the levers that remain
Delay / the record:		more achievable than a full stop
Single step:		5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Czechia are **the protective limit, the community that holds the line, and the endurance**, backed by the national movement and the courts. Horní Jiřetín shows the ceiling: a town invoked a protective limit and held firm for twenty years, and the excavators were kept back. But the honest floor is real too: the win was mixed — a limit lifted elsewhere — it leaned partly on the coal's decline, and the threat was long-lived. Most Czech fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the protective limit, the community's resolve, the endurance, and the national movement are powerful levers — decisive when a line exists and the community holds it, weaker when it does not, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and a partial gain. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a community protected by a clear limit, resolved to hold it, is in the strong band and can aim to keep the excavators back and save its town, as Horní Jiřetín did; a community with no clear protective line, or whose resolve is fracturing under the pressure and the offers, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a record, and a partial gain while it works to establish a protective line and shore up its unity. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The protective limit and the community that holds it** — Czechia's most distinctive lever; the line drawn in law and the town's refusal to be dug up, as at Horní Jiřetín.
2. **The endurance over decades** — the resolve to hold firm for as long as it takes, outlasting the company and the government.
3. **The national movement and the climate frame** — the movement and the coal-phase-out argument that lift a local fight to a national cause.
4. **The courts and EU law** — the process and legal challenges that review and can halt a project.
5. **The determined local leader and the town's unity** — the mayor and the community, whose steadfastness and legitimacy anchor the whole fight.

What Czech Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **A protective limit can be held** — Horní Jiřetín held the mining limits. **A town can refuse to be dug up** — the community would not move. **Endurance wins** — twenty years of resolve outlasted the company. **A national movement lifts a local fight** — "we are the limits" made it a national cause. **But the win is mixed and the threat long-lived** — a limit was lifted elsewhere, and the vigilance never ends. The through-line: **invoke the protective limit; document the harm; build the movement; hold the line for as long as it takes; and rouse the nation — because in Czechia a determined community can defend a protective line and save its very existence.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds, which in Czechia is often the protective limit, the community's resolve, and the flawed process. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the mine expansion that would breach the protective limit and demolish our town" is a campaign — the kind that saved Horní Jiřetín. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Is there a protective limit or line to invoke? This is the first Czech question. Is there a **mining limit, a boundary, a protected status, or a guarantee** that protects the place — as the mining limits protected Horní Jiřetín — that can be invoked and defended? This should be among the first things a campaign establishes, because the existence of a protective line transforms the whole character of the fight. Where a firm limit, boundary, or guarantee protects the place, the community's task is to defend an existing line — a strong, clear, and morally weighty position; where no such line exists, the community must fight the project on its merits alone, or work to establish a protective line, which is harder.

Determining early whether a mining limit, a protected-area boundary, a zoning guarantee, or some other protective line covers the place, and what it promised, tells a campaign at once whether it holds the distinctive Czech lever or must build one.

2. Will the community hold the line? Will the **community — the town, the neighbours — stand firm and refuse to be moved or overrun**, for as long as it takes, as Horní Jiřetín stood firm for twenty years? Assess this honestly at the outset, because the community's resolve is the load-bearing element of the whole strategy, and a fight to hold a line is a test of endurance above all. A powerful company facing a determined community rarely attacks head-on; it works patiently to erode the resolve — buying up properties, offering generous compensation to those who will sell, spreading uncertainty about the town's future, waiting for the young to leave and the old to tire. A campaign must therefore reckon frankly with whether its community can hold together through years of such pressure, and make the sustaining of that unity and resolve — not merely the legal and political fight — a central task, as Horní Jiřetín did in keeping its people and its purpose through two decades.

3. What does it do to the town, the land, and the people? What **harm** does the project cause — the demolition of homes, the loss of a town, the pollution of air and land, the displacement of people — and what does the community stand to lose, as Horní Jiřetín stood to lose everything? Give particular weight to documenting the total and irreversible nature of the loss, because that is what most distinguishes this kind of fight and most moves a nation. A polluting project may be argued to bring some offsetting benefit; the demolition of a town erases something that can never be recovered — the homes, the streets, the church, the graves, the centuries of a community's life in one place. A campaign that documents not merely that the project is harmful but that it would annihilate a living community and its entire history, permanently and for coal that will be burned in a season, gives the nation the sharpest possible reason to refuse, as the prospect of erasing a seven-and-a-half-century-old town gave the country its reason to spare Horní Jiřetín.

4. Was the process lawful, and can the nation be roused? Was the **process and assessment** lawful, and can a **national movement and the climate frame** lift the fight to a national cause?

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which company, government body, and owner are behind it, who profits; and which courts, the limits, the EU, the organisations, the movements, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a mine or development would breach a protective limit and demolish or overrun a community, on a flawed process.

Working the five questions: is there a **protective limit** to invoke? Will the **community hold**? What **harm** to the town and the people? Was the **process lawful**, and can the **nation be roused**? And the deciders are the company and the government, with the courts, the limits, the EU, the movements, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will dig us up" to a target list: invoke the protective limit; document the harm; build the movement; hold the line; and rouse the nation. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how a town saved itself. Notice what the exercise did: it turned an existential dread — the fear of being dug up — into a set of concrete, winnable tasks: invoke the limit, document the harm, build the movement, hold the line, rouse the nation, each tied to a specific lever that Czechia genuinely provides. That reframing, from "they will dig us up and nothing can be done" to a plan built on a protective line and a town's resolve, is the difference the five questions make, and the first of them, whether a protective limit exists to invoke, often decides how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, an official, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Czechia, the protective limit, the harm, and the flawed process are precisely what a campaign turns into a defence, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Limit, and the Process

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **project plans, the permits, the environmental assessment, and — distinctively — the protective limit or guarantee** and its legal basis, as Horní Jiřetín's defenders held the 1991 mining limits and their meaning. Scrutinise the process and the assessment for flaws, and establish exactly **what the**

protective limit protects and how it was meant to be permanent — because the limit, and the guarantee it represented, is your strongest ground. The gap between the guarantee the limit gave and the breach the project would require is where many Czech cases are grounded. The history and meaning of the protective limit therefore deserve careful documentation, because a campaign's strongest argument is often not merely that a limit exists but why it was drawn and what it promised. The mining limits of North Bohemia were established as a deliberate remedy for a specific injustice — the demolition of towns and the poisoning of a region under the old regime — and as an explicit guarantee to the survivors that they had a secure future; establishing that history turns the limit from a dry administrative boundary into a solemn commitment whose breach is a betrayal. A community that documents not only the letter of its protective line but the promise behind it arms itself with the moral weight that, in these fights, often proves decisive.

Layer 2: The Harm to the Town, the Land, and the People

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **town, the land, the air, and the people** at the centre. Record the **harm** — the demolition of the town, the loss of homes and history, the pollution, the displacement — that the project would cause, as Horní Jiřetín documented the threat to a 750-year-old town. Document what would be **lost**, and the human cost of being dug up. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from residents, and gather the **scientific and health evidence** on the pollution and the impact. This is the human case that unites the community and moves the nation.

Layer 3: The Guarantee, the Harm, and the Injustice

Finally, document the case. Does a **protective limit or guarantee** protect the place, and would the project **breach it**? Is the **harm** — the demolition, the loss, the pollution — real and grave? And is there an **injustice** — a community made to be dug up, its guarantee broken, for a company's profit? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, the campaign, and the nation — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Czech fights, because here a project sold as necessary is revealed to break a solemn guarantee, to demolish a town, and to sacrifice a community for profit — exactly the case that saved Horní Jiřetín. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the breach of the protective guarantee, the demolition of a living town, and the injustice of sacrificing a community for profit — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the broken guarantee is what the government and the courts must answer for, the human demolition is what moves the nation, and the injustice is what shames the project and the profit behind it. A campaign that documents only the harm may stir sympathy without a clear line to defend; one that documents only the limit may win a technical point without the nation's heart; the campaigns that prevail in Czechia, as Horní Jiřetín's did, build all three and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Czech cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the protective limit, the harm, and the injustice.

The Project, the Limit, and the Paper Trail

- **The project plans and the permits** — how the project was authorised, and by which body.
- **The protective limit or guarantee** — the mining limit, boundary, or protected status, and its legal basis and history.
- **The environmental assessment** — the study behind the decision, and its adequacy under national and EU law.
- **The health and pollution data** — the impact on the town's air, land, and people.
- **The company and the beneficiaries** — who profits, who owns the company, and its ties.

How to Get Them

The plans, permits, and assessment are matters of record, obtainable from the authorities and through Czechia's and the EU's access-to-information rules; the protective limit and its history from the government records and the environmental authorities; the health and pollution data through the assessment, independent measurement, and the scientists. Lean on **allies**: Czechia's environmental organisations and national movements, its lawyers versed in EU environmental law, its scientists, and the experienced campaigners of past coal fights. Move promptly: documenting the limit and the harm early lets you invoke the guarantee and rouse the nation before the decision hardens, as Horní Jiřetín's defenders held the line from the start. Timing matters here in a particular way, because a protective limit is easier to defend before a decision to breach it has gathered momentum than after. The moment a company or a government begins to press for lifting a limit, the community should be ready — its documentation of the limit and its promise in hand, its resolve declared, its allies engaged — so that the proposal to breach the line meets an organised defence from the outset rather than a scramble to

catch up. Horní Jiřetín's long vigilance meant that every renewed push to breach the limit was met by a community already mobilised; a campaign that establishes its defence early, and keeps it ready, is far better placed than one that must build it under the pressure of an imminent decision.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — the demolition, the displacement, the pollution, the loss of a town, documented.
- **The protective limit** — the guarantee, its legal basis, and what a breach would mean.
- **The injustice** — a community dug up, its guarantee broken, for a company's profit.
- **The health and pollution data** — the numbers that show the impact.
- **Testimony and science** — from residents, scientists, and the movements who know the fight.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the project, the limit, the assessment, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, and a member of the government all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company or the government pushes back. In a country where the protective limit and the human harm decide, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest proof of the guarantee and the demolition it would break — is very often the one that holds the line, as Horní Jiřetín held it.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE TOWN AND THE NATION

Evidence and limits do not win on their own. An organised, determined community does — and in Czechia, Horní Jiřetín proved that a town resolved to save its own existence, joined to a national movement, can hold the line for twenty years and win. A campaign's strength here is that community: united, enduring, holding the line, and lifted to a national cause.

Phase 1: The Core and the Town

Start with a committed core rooted in the **whole town** — because in Czechia the community's resolve to save its own existence is the decisive lever. A determined **local leader** — a mayor, a respected figure — can anchor the fight, as Horní Jiřetín's mayor anchored it. Assign roles — documentation, legal, the limit and the guarantee, media, and movement liaison. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the limit held, the town saved — and on what the community will and will not accept. Draw on the town's own bonds and its refusal to be moved.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **whole town and the neighbouring communities**; the **environmental organisations**, which bring the campaigning and the legal expertise; the **national movements** — like the one whose name declared "we are the limits" — which lift the fight to a national cause; the **scientists**, on the pollution and the health impact; sympathetic **lawyers**; and the **wider public**, whom the injustice of a town dug up can move. Reach the **free press**, because a town facing demolition for coal is a national story. Horní Jiřetín's fight drew its power from exactly this breadth — a determined town, environmentalists, a national movement, and a roused public — which is precisely the spread a winning Czech campaign needs. The role of the national movement in that coalition deserves particular emphasis, because it is what lifts a single town's survival into a cause the whole country will defend. A local community, however determined, can be portrayed as a narrow interest standing in the way of the nation's energy and jobs; a national movement reframes the fight as one about the country's future — whether it keeps its promises, whether it clings to coal or moves beyond it, whether it will dig up its own people for profit. The movement that took the limits as its name did exactly this for Horní Jiřetín, and a campaign that connects its local fight to such a national and climate cause gains a reach and a legitimacy that the town alone could never command.

A worked coalition example. Facing a mine that would demolish a town, the community and its mayor form the base and hold the line; the environmental organisations bring the campaign and the legal fight; the national movement lifts it to a climate cause; the scientists document the harm; and the press carries it to the nation. No single group could carry it; together they cover the limit, the harm, the law, and the nation — the model Horní Jiřetín built. What is worth drawing from

that model is how each element supplied what the others could not: the town and its mayor brought the standing and the moral force of those whose homes were at stake; the environmental organisations brought the campaigning and the legal expertise; the national movement brought the reach that made a town's survival a national and climate cause; the scientists brought the evidence of the pollution and the harm; and the press carried it all to the country. A community beginning such a fight should honestly assess which of these it holds and which it must recruit, because it is the completeness of the coalition — above all the joining of a determined town to a national movement — that made Horní Jiřetín's twenty-year defence hold.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Czech fight to hold a line can run for decades, as Horní Jiřetín's ran for twenty years. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the limit reaffirmed, an assessment challenged, a climate camp held, a court filing, a wave of coverage, an election won. Keep the town united and the movement engaged, and guard against the **exhaustion and the pressure** — the years of uncertainty, the offers and threats, the temptation to give up and take the compensation — that a long fight and a powerful company will bring to bear. Meeting this pressure is one of the campaign's hardest and most necessary tasks, because a company that cannot defeat a united community will patiently try to divide it. The generous offer to an individual homeowner, the quiet purchase of a key property, the cultivated sense that resistance is futile and the town's end inevitable — these are the tools used to erode a community's resolve one household at a time, and they are often more dangerous than any open confrontation. A campaign must meet them not by condemning those tempted, who face a genuine and painful choice, but by sustaining a shared conviction that the town has a future worth staying for, and by demonstrating, through every reprieve won and every year the line holds, that the resolve is not futile — as Horní Jiřetín demonstrated it, until the town was saved. Above all, keep holding the line and keep the town's resolve, because a community that endures, refusing to be moved year after year, outlasts a company and a government, as Horní Jiřetín outlasted them.

Phase 4: Holding the Line, and Lifting It to the Nation

Here is Czechia's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, **hold the line**: keep the community's resolve to invoke the protective limit and refuse to be moved, for as long as it takes, as Horní Jiřetín held firm for twenty years — because the determined refusal to be dug up is a power a company and a government struggle to overcome. Second, **lift it to the nation**: turn the local fight into a **national cause** — through the national movement, the climate and coal-phase-out argument, and the injustice of a town demolished for profit — so that the whole country stands behind the line, as the movement that declared "we are the limits" put the nation behind Horní Jiřetín. Keep it **determined, enduring, and nationally connected**, because in Czechia it is the town that holds the line and the nation that stands behind it, more than any single confrontation, that saves a community from the excavators.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE LIMITS, THE PROCESS, AND THE COURTS

Czechia's protective limits, its courts and environmental process, and the EU framework are a real legal toolkit — and the distinctive one is the **protective limit** itself, a line drawn in law and policy that a community can invoke and defend. You do not need a single courtroom victory to win: a limit reaffirmed, a decision quashed, a process reopened, a delay while you hold the line, or a project abandoned under pressure can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and experts early — but understand the tools.

The Protective Limit

The first and most distinctive lever is the **protective limit** itself. Czechia's **mining limits** — and, more broadly, any boundary, protected status, or guarantee that protects a place — are a real constraint, and a project that would **breach the limit** can be opposed on that ground, and the government pressed to uphold it, as Horní Jiřetín pressed the government to keep the limits at ČSA. Invoke the limit, insist on the guarantee it represented, and make its breach the central issue; the limit is the line the whole fight defends. It is worth being clear-eyed about the legal nature of such a limit, because it shapes how a community must defend it. A mining limit set by government resolution is a policy commitment rather than an unbreakable law, which means it can, in principle, be revised by a later government — and this is precisely why the fight is as much political as legal. A community cannot simply rely on the limit as a fixed wall; it must defend the limit politically, by making its breach costly and dishonourable, while using every legal and procedural tool to slow and complicate any attempt to lift it. The strength of the limit, in the end, lies less in its legal form than in the community and the nation determined to hold the government to it.

The Process and the Courts

The second lever is the **process and the courts**. A Czech project requires **permits and an environmental assessment**, and a decision made on a **flawed assessment**, without proper participation, or contrary to the law can be challenged in the courts, as environmental cases here have been. A campaign should study the procedural requirements closely, because even where the deeper fight is over the protective limit, the ordinary law of assessment and permitting offers real opportunities to delay and to challenge. A large mine or its expansion requires environmental assessment and a chain of permits, each of which must meet legal standards and allow for public participation, and each of which can be contested where those standards were not met. Such challenges may not by themselves stop a determined project, but they buy the time in which the community can hold the line, the movement can grow, and the nation can be roused — and in a fight measured in years, as these fights are, the time that a procedural challenge wins is itself valuable. Scrutinise the process and the assessment, and challenge a flawed decision — and use the time a challenge buys to hold the line and rouse the nation, because delay keeps a project open to defeat.

EU Environmental Law

The third lever is **EU environmental law**. As an EU member, Czechia is bound by the EU's **environmental-assessment, nature-protection, and public-participation law**, which gives communities rights to information, consultation, and challenge, and — where a project breaches EU law — grounds to stop it, reaching, through the national courts, to the European Court of Justice. Invoke the EU framework where it applies, adding its weight to the defence of the limit. The EU dimension is worth pursuing wherever a project engages it, because it adds a layer of protection beyond the reach of any single national government. Where a mine or development would harm a habitat or species protected under EU nature law, or where the required EU environmental assessment was inadequate or the public-participation rights denied, the case becomes a matter of European as well as Czech law, enforceable through the national courts and, ultimately, referable to the European Court of Justice. This gives a community a further, powerful ground, and one that a national government tempted to breach a limit cannot simply override; a campaign should establish early whether its fight engages EU environmental law and, if it does, make full use of that leverage.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Invoking the limit goes through the **government and the process**; process and legal challenges through the **courts**; the EU-law grounds through the **EU framework and the courts**. Get help early: Czechia's environmental organisations, its national movements, and its lawyers versed in EU environmental law know the limits, the process, and the courts. Help engaged early — before the decision hardens — is worth far more than help sought after, and in Czechia the strongest strategy marries the **protective limit and the legal challenge** to the **community that holds the line and the nation behind it**, so that a project cannot breach the line the law drew and the people defend.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an official, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine expansion would breach a protective limit drawn to guarantee a town's future and demolish that 750-year-old town for coal, on a decision made against a solemn guarantee. That one fact becomes:

- **A limit argument:** the project would breach a protective limit and the guarantee it gave — the case that defends the line.
- **A legal argument:** the decision breaks the guarantee and rests on a flawed process — the case before the courts.
- **A human argument:** a town, its homes and history, would be dug up and its people displaced — the case that moves the nation.
- **A climate argument:** more coal would be burned when the country should be leaving it behind — the case that lifts the fight to a national and global cause.
- **An injustice argument:** a community would be sacrificed and its guarantee broken for a company's profit — the case that shames the project.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each

audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Czechia the arguments that most often decide things are the **limit** one, because it defends the line, and the **human** one, because the demolition of a town for coal moves a nation. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the record and a claim made to a judge can be proven by the guarantee; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the breach of the guarantee and the flawed process framed against the law, with the documents that prove them.

The government responds to the protective limit it drew, the national movement, the legal risk, and the political cost of demolishing a town.

Journalists need a specific, vivid, human story: a 750-year-old town, its people, about to be dug up for coal.

The public needs the argument simple and true: a town and its people, sacrificed for coal and profit — not while we watch.

The scientists respond to the honest technical case on the pollution, the health, and the climate.

The national movement needs the fight framed as a national cause — the line, the town, the climate — worth standing behind.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Czechia, where the demolition of a town for coal is a story that stirs a nation, coverage that carries the human injustice and the climate stakes is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage rouses the nation, shifts opinion, and raises the political cost. Horní Jiřetín's fight became a national cause because it told a story the country could grasp: a living town, with a young population that wanted to stay, marked to be dug up for coal against a promise once made to protect it.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the human and the moral. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a 750-year-old town, its homes and its history and its people, would be demolished for coal, against a solemn promise drawn to protect it" is — the story that saved Horní Jiřetín. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the demolition, the broken guarantee, the pollution — and offer a human voice: a resident, the mayor, a young person who wants to stay. In Czechia the story of a town about to be dug up, against its right and its will, is one the nation responds to.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because in a small country the national conversation is where a threatened town becomes a national cause, and the government feels it. Then the **international and climate ring** — the international press and the climate movement — because the fight against coal and for a town's survival resonates across borders and adds real weight, as the climate camp at Horní Jiřetín drew international attention. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national ring is decisive** in Czechia, because national opinion and the ballot box move the government.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Czech fight to hold a line runs for years. Plan a sequence — the threat, the guarantee, the demolition, the movement, the government's decision — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; the company and the government will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, human-and-limit-centred campaign is what moves a nation. Verified, specific, town-and-guarantee-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped save a town.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the authorities, the company, the courts, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the limit, the process, and the harm.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant authority **Subject:** Request for information on [project]

Under the access-to-information and environmental-information rules, we, [community/organisation], request the **project plans, the permits, the environmental assessment, and the documents concerning the protective limit or guarantee** relating to [project]. This project affects our town and the public interest, and the public has a right to know. Please provide the documents.

8B. Objection Invoking the Protective Limit

To: the government / the permitting authority **Subject:** Objection to [project] — breach of the protective limit and demolition of [town]

We, [community/organisation], object to [project]. It would **breach the protective limit / guarantee** that protects [town], **demolish our homes and community**, and cause [the pollution and harm], against the solemn guarantee that limit represented. We demand that the limit be **upheld** and the project **refused**, and we reserve our right to the courts.

8C. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the court (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to the decision on [project]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge the decision on [project] as **unlawful**: it would breach the **protective limit and guarantee**, rests on a **flawed assessment**, and denied proper **participation**, contrary to national and EU law. We seek its **annulment** and the halting of works, and attach the record demonstrating the flaws and the harm.

8D. Letter to the Company

To: the company **Subject:** The community's opposition to [project]

We write regarding [project] at [town]. The community opposes it: it would breach a protective limit, demolish our town and homes, and sacrifice our community for coal and profit. We call on you to **abandon** the expansion, and we advise that the town will hold the line, invoke the limit, challenge the decision, and rouse the nation, as Horní Jiřetín did.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Organisation

To: a public-interest lawyer / environmental organisation **Subject:** [Project] — the limit, the harm, and the challenge

We are opposing [project] at [town]. We attach the plans, the assessment, the documents on the protective limit, and our evidence of harm, and seek advice on **invoking and defending the limit, the legal and EU-law challenge**, and **defending the community**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8F. Appeal to a National Movement / Allies

To: an environmental or climate movement / ally **Subject:** Support for [town]'s stand against [project]

We write regarding [project], which would demolish our town for coal and breach the limit drawn to protect it. As the movement that declared "we are the limits" stood with Horní Jiřetín, we ask for your **support, your voice, and your reach** to lift our fight to a national cause. We attach our case and can host you at the town.

8G. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the town / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a human story the nation should know, with a clear hook: [documents] show

[finding — e.g. "a 750-year-old town would be demolished for coal, against a solemn promise drawn to protect it"]. It echoes Horní Jiřetín. I can share the file and connect you with a resident and the mayor. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/organisation] will not be dug up

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would **demolish our town** and breach the **protective limit** drawn to guarantee our future. As Horní Jiřetín held the line and saved itself, we will invoke the limit, hold firm, challenge the decision, and call on the nation. We call on the government to keep its guarantee, not to dig up its own people, and we will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an objection invoking the limit, or a challenge is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the government, and the nation will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the limit, the process, and the harm; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the community, the organisations, the movements, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in Czechia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the protective limit, the community that holds the line, and the national movement that saved a town.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can hold a line for twenty years. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to defend a place. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find the protective limit.** Learn whether a mining limit, boundary, or guarantee protects your place, and get its documents (Step 1, 8A).
- 2. Document the harm.** Establish what the project would demolish and pollute, and what would be lost (Step 2).
- 3. Object, invoking the limit.** Put your objection, the breach of the limit, and the harm on the record (8B).
- 4. Rally the town.** Bring the community together in the resolve to hold the line (Step 3).
- 5. Reach the movements and lawyers.** Connect with environmental and climate movements and lawyers (8F, 8E).
- 6. Rouse the nation.** Take the human injustice and the climate stakes to the press (Step 5, 8G).
- 7. Challenge the decision.** With a lawyer, challenge a flawed decision in court (8D).

Do only the first three and you will have found the limit, documented the harm, and put your objection on the record — the foundation of a Czech defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: find the limit, document the harm, object.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Czechia's system, as a democracy and an EU member, is by global standards favourable — but it is not without its tilts, and you must understand them so you neither waste effort nor grow complacent.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. **Powerful coal, energy, and industrial interests** — sometimes owned by wealthy and connected figures — carry weight, and a project is presented as energy security and jobs. A **rich and determined company** can wear a community down over years with offers, pressure, and patience. **Governments can be tempted** by the coal and the revenue to breach a protective limit. And a fight to hold a line can take **so long** that a community tires. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the protective limit is safe, or that a determined company will give up quickly, will be disappointed — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to hold the line, for as long as it takes, with the nation behind you.

What Still Works — And Much Is Strong

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, Czechia's levers are, by any comparison, real and strong.

A protective limit still holds. A line drawn in law and defended by a community and a government can keep the excavators back, as it kept them from Horní Jiřetín.

A determined community still prevails. A town resolved to save its existence is a powerful and legitimate force.

Endurance still wins. A community that holds firm for as long as it takes can outlast a company and a government.

The national movement still lifts the fight. A national cause and the climate frame move the country and the government.

The courts and EU law still constrain. Czechia's courts and the EU framework are real checks on a flawed decision.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Czechia is genuinely hopeful, with a caution against complacency and against giving up: the levers are strong, the protective limit real, the courts genuine, and a determined community powerful — but the win may be mixed, it may lean partly on outside forces, and the threat is long-lived, the vigilance constant. So diagnose your fight honestly: invoke the **protective limit**; document the **harm and the demolition**; build the **movement**; **hold the line** for as long as it takes; **rouse the nation**; and use the **courts** — while understanding that the fight may take decades and the vigilance never fully ends. Do not assume the limit is safe or the company will tire first; Horní Jiřetín was saved because a town held the line for twenty years and would not be dug up.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Czechia is a functioning democracy and EU member, but it has had real and documented concerns about the influence of wealthy and connected interests over decisions, so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the public interest but by the connected, or by a powerful company's weight over the institutions, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **decision to breach a protective limit pushed against the public interest and the guarantee**; an **assessment shaded** to favour a chosen project; **close ties** between the company, its wealthy owners, and decision-makers; **public interest sacrificed** to a private profit; and **benefits to the connected** while a community is dug up. Trace the decision and the interests: who pushed the breach, who profits, whether the guarantee was to be broken for the connected. In Czechia, a decision to demolish a town and break a solemn limit for a powerful company's coal is worth examining for the influence behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where influence reaches. **Parts of the government and the institutions** can be swayed by powerful economic interests and wealthy owners. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, and through EU law the **European Court of Justice**; the **EU institutions**; the **environmental organisations and national movements**; the **free press**; and the **public and the voters**, whose feeling for a threatened town decides. Distinctively, the national movement and the public feeling for a community about to be dug up are hard to capture and powerful to rouse; your task is to document the capture, defend the limit, and bring it to the courts, the press, and the nation.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured decision to breach a limit cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the breach was pushed, who profits, what guarantee was to be broken — and take it to the forces that can act: the **courts, up to the ECJ**; the **EU institutions**; the **free press and the national movement**, to expose it; and the **public and the voters**, to move it. Pair the exposure with the defence of the limit and the human harm, so the impropriety and the injustice arrive together. In Czechia, exposing how a solemn limit was to be broken and a town dug up for a connected company's profit, and rousing the nation to defend it, is often the way to stop it — as the exposure and the pressure

helped keep the limits at Horní Jiřetín.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Czechia turns on the protective limit, the community that holds the line, and the national movement.

Early (Months 0-8): The Limit, the Harm, and the Town

Pin down the project and the deciding bodies (Step 1); establish the **protective limit** and document the **harm and the demolition** (Step 2). Rally the **town** and build the **coalition** with the environmental organisations and movements (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); **object, invoking the limit** (8B); reach **lawyers and movements** early (8E, 8F); and begin to **rouse the nation** (Step 5). This phase lays the foundation, and in Czechia the invoked limit and the united town established here are what win.

Middle (Months 6-many): Hold, Challenge, and Rouse

Sustain the town and the movement, and **hold the line** (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Mount the **legal and EU-law challenge** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, carrying the human injustice and the climate stakes (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — invoking the limit and challenging before a decision to breach it hardens — because those chances are most powerful early, and the fight may then run for years.

Later (Years, Not Months): The Decision, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **limit upheld, the project stopped, the town saved** — and then stay vigilant, because, as Horní Jiřetín showed, a limit is a decision a later government could revisit, and the threat can return. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a limit upheld and a town saved outright. Sometimes it is a mixed decision — a line held here, given up there — or a reprieve that must be defended again. Both, where they hold the excavators back, are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

YEAR 0-1	Establish the limit + document the harm Rally the town Object invoking the limit Reach movements + lawyers
YEAR 1-many	Hold the line Legal + EU-law challenge Rouse the nation Media
YEARS on	Limit upheld / town saved Stay vigilant, for a limit can be revisited

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Czechia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. A **protective limit** — a line drawn in law and policy — can be invoked and defended to keep a destructive project back, as the mining limits kept the excavators from Horní Jiřetín. A **community determined to save its own existence** is a powerful and legitimate force. **Endurance over decades** can outlast even a wealthy company and a tempted government. And a **national movement**, with the climate and the human injustice behind it, can lift a local fight to a national cause. These are the tools that let a 750-year-old town refuse to be dug up for coal — and win.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The decision that saved Horní Jiřetín was **mixed** — a limit lifted at another mine even as it was kept here. The win leaned partly on the **coal's own declining economics**, not on resistance alone. And the threat was **long-lived** — the limit a decision a later government could revisit, the vigilance constant. No guide should pretend these away; in Czechia, the art is to invoke the limit, hold the line for as long as it takes, rouse the nation, and keep watch, because a line held can be threatened again.

So the realistic promise is this: **invoke the protective limit; document the harm and the demolition; build the movement; hold the line for as long as it takes; rouse the nation; and use the courts — running all of it together.** Do that, and where a limit exists and the community holds it, you can keep the excavators back and save your town, as Horní Jiřetín did; where it does not, you can still win delay, a record, and a partial gain. Do it as Horní Jiřetín did —

a town that invoked a solemn guarantee, held the line for twenty years, and would not be dug up.

A last word on holding the line. Czechia's lesson is that a line once drawn — a limit, a guarantee, a promise to a community — holds more power than the powerful want you to believe, and that a determined town, refusing to be moved and standing firm for as long as it takes, can defend that line and save its very existence — but that the win may be mixed, may lean on forces beyond the fight, and demands a vigilance that never fully ends. The powerful count on your believing the coal is worth too much and your resolve too weak to last. Their advantage is the wealth of the company, the patience of the pressure, and the temptation of the compensation. Yours is the protective limit, the town that will not move, the endurance that outlasts them, the national movement behind you, the courts and EU law, and the proven fact that Horní Jiřetín held the line and was saved. Play to that. Keep the record and the proof of the limit and the harm, keep the town united and the line held, rouse the nation, and treat every objection, every filing, every year the town holds, and every limit upheld as a stone in a wall that even the excavators cannot climb.

The tools are here, and Czechia itself proved them: a 750-year-old town, marked to be dug up for coal, that invoked the limit drawn to protect it, held the line for twenty years against a wealthy company and a tempted government, and was saved. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the protective limit, the community's resolve to hold it, the endurance over the long years, and the nation roused behind it — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the limit and the harm and the rallying of the town, and build from there. Communities before you have held the line and saved their homes — a limit upheld, a town spared, the excavators kept back. What Horní Jiřetín won can be won again. Every limit upheld, every town spared, every year a community holds firm builds on that example and makes the next such defence a little more winnable, by proving that a promise can be kept, that a town can refuse to be erased, and that endurance, in the end, can outlast even the excavators and the wealth behind them. So can yours.